Make sure your cauliflower is impeccably fresh, and check that the cheese really is smoked, and not just laced with fake smoke flavoring, as some are.

smoked cauliflower cheese soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 15–20 MINS **COOK** 25–30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE CHEESE IS ADDED

1 cauliflower, broken into florets
1 large onion, chopped
1 medium floury potato, cut into cubes
2 garlic cloves, sliced
1 bouquet garni (see p24)
2 tbsp butter
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
3½oz (100g) coarsely grated smoked cheddar
a shake of cayenne pepper, freshly chopped parsley or chives, croûtons, or a dollop of sour cream, to garnish

1 Cook the vegetables, garlic, and bouquet garni with the butter in a covered pan over low heat for 10 minutes, stirring once or twice. Add the stock, a little salt, and lots of freshly ground black pepper and bring to a boil. Simmer until the cauliflower and potato are just tender (don't overcook). Remove the bouquet garni and process the soup in a blender until smooth, adding more stock or a little milk to thin it down as necessary.

2 Reheat the soup gently, but do not allow it to boil. Stir in two-thirds of the cheese, taste, and see if you think it needs more. Add it if it does. Taste one more time, then serve with the garnish of your choice.



CAULIFLOWER
You can find various types of organic cauliflower, including purple, orange, white, and miniature. Look for those with tight, firm heads and bright green leaves. The stalks can be used for flavoring soup or stock.